

Accredian Connect

Product Feature Plan : Student Communication Dashboard

Submitted by: Ujjaval Bhardwaj **Role Applied:** Product Management Intern

Live Prototype: <https://accerdian-connect-pm.vercel.app/>

Table of Contents

1. Background
 2. Problem Statements
 3. Goals
 4. Hypothesis & Feature Description
 5. Vision Narrative
 6. Key Trade Offs & Decisions
 7. Concept Mocks
 8. Badges & Recognition System
 9. Leaderboard
 10. Product Metrics
 11. How we launch
 12. Risks & Mitigations
 13. Appendix
-

1. Background

Accredian offers postgraduate programs in Data Science, AI/ML, and Product Management in partnership with IIT Kanpur, IIM Lucknow, XLRI, and others. The students are working professionals managing full-time jobs while attending live classes on weekends.

The platform delivers live instruction, mentorship, and assignments effectively. But there is one gap that has gone unaddressed: students have no space inside Accredian to communicate with each other between sessions.

Because of this, students create their own WhatsApp groups, Telegram channels, and LinkedIn threads. Resources get buried. Questions go unanswered. Mentors have no visibility into what is happening outside of live class hours. Accredian loses all engagement data, community signals, and retention opportunities to external platforms it has no control over.

Accredian Connect is built to fix this. A communication dashboard integrated directly inside the student portal structured, private, and built around learning outcomes rather than general messaging.

2. Problem Statements

The Student I am a working professional enrolled in an Accredited program. I am trying to connect with my batchmates, get questions answered, and access shared resources. But I rely on WhatsApp where messages are unorganized and important information disappears within hours. This makes me feel disconnected from my cohort and unsupported between live sessions.

The Mentor I am a mentor at Accredian. I am trying to keep students engaged and guide learning between sessions. But I have no structured way to interact with students inside the platform after class ends. My impact is limited to scheduled hours, which is not enough to drive the learning outcomes we want.

The Platform Accredian wants to build a strong learning community and improve student retention. But with all peer communication happening externally, there is no visibility into student engagement outside of class, no way to identify struggling students early, and no mechanism to keep alumni connected after course completion.

3. Goals

The goal of Accredian Connect is to make students prefer the platform for all academic communication instead of defaulting to WhatsApp, Telegram, or LinkedIn.

Success looks like:

1. Currently zero percent of student communication happens inside the Accredian platform.
 2. 70% of newly enrolled students actively using Accredian Connect within 3 months of launch
 3. Measurable increase in time students spend on the platform outside of live class hours
 4. Mentors leading discussions and responding to queries directly inside the platform
 5. Students finding any resource or discussion in under 30 seconds through search
 6. Improvement in course completion rates and end-of-course satisfaction scores
 7. Reduction in external communication groups created by enrolled students over time
-

4. Hypothesis & Feature Description

Hypothesis

If students are given a communication platform built specifically for learning with structured discussions, study rooms, organized resources, mentorship access, and a merit-based career pathway they will choose it over WhatsApp because it solves problems a general messaging app cannot.

Feature Description

Accredian Connect is integrated directly into the existing student portal. No separate app, no new login. The moment a student enrolls, they are already inside it.

The platform has three core spaces.

Space 1 : Open Community

A public space where students, mentors, and selected alumni from any Accredian program can participate together regardless of course or batch.

Students can post discussions, share resources, filter content by category (All Posts, Mentor Posts, Trending, Resources, AMA Sessions), and discover active Study Rooms. Upcoming cohort dates for all programs are visible here so current students can refer peers and prospective students can plan enrollment.

Privacy: Only name and batch are publicly visible. No phone numbers or personal details. Private messaging requires the other person to accept a request first, no unsolicited DMs.

Study Rooms are part of the Open Community. Any student from any course can join at any time. Camera is optional. Microphone is permanently off for all students only Accredian admins can enable it in exceptional cases. A shared room chat allows text communication without disturbing the silent study environment. The number of people currently in each room is visible on the listing page to encourage others to join.

Since Study Rooms are open to all courses and batches, there is always someone present regardless of the time of day — which is the core motivation mechanism for working professionals studying alone.

Space 2 : Course Community

A private space limited to students within the same cohort and their assigned mentors. Everything here is tied directly to the course structure.

Four tabs organize the experience:

Course Feed : General cohort discussions and mentor-led prompts. Mentors post at least one discussion topic per week to keep the cohort engaged between live sessions.

Module Discussions : Every module has its own thread showing resource count and discussion count. Students navigate directly to the relevant module instead of scrolling through a general chat to find context.

Resource Library : All shared PDFs, links, and recordings are automatically tagged by module using AI. Students search and find any resource in seconds.

Announcements : Deadline changes, new mentor introductions, upcoming events — all in a dedicated tab so nothing critical gets buried.

Private messaging within the Course Community follows the same rule — message requests only, accepted or ignored by the recipient.

Space 3 : Private Chat

Available only after a message request is accepted, whether sent from the Open Community or Course Community. Fully one-on-one and consent-based at every step.

AI : Two Specific Jobs Only

AI inside Accredian Connect is intentionally limited to two use cases. Students already have ChatGPT for general questions. If AI starts answering questions inside the community it replaces the human interaction this platform is designed to enable. AI here only organizes what humans already said.

Smart Catch-Up: A student who has been offline for a few days asks what they missed. AI summarizes the key discussions, resources shared, and announcements from that period. This is not something WhatsApp can offer.

Auto Resource Tagging: When a resource is shared inside any community, AI tags it with the relevant course, module, and topic automatically. Students search and find it later without scrolling through old messages.

Alumni Access : Selective Opt-In

Not every Accredian graduate gets alumni mentor access. Only those who apply or are invited and genuinely want to contribute are given the Alumni Mentor tag. This keeps guidance quality high and makes the alumni presence on the platform credible and intentional.

5. Vision Narrative

Meet Priya.

Priya is a 28-year-old marketing professional in Bangalore. She enrolled in Accredian's Product Management program to transition into a PM role within the year. She is motivated but stretched to a full-time job during the week, classes on weekends, very little margin for wasted time.

Before Accredian Connect

The day after her first class, a batchmate adds her to a WhatsApp group. Within 48 hours there are 300 messages, memes, assignment questions, and somewhere buried in the middle, a product framework document she can no longer find. She posts a question about her first assignment. It disappears under 60 new messages within an hour. She tries finding Accredian alumni on LinkedIn but cannot identify who completed her specific program. She sends four connection requests to strangers. One replies three days later.

She starts questioning whether she made the right decision enrolling.

After Accredian Connect

The moment her enrollment is confirmed she is inside her Course Community 45 batchmates and two mentors, already active. Her mentor has posted a discussion prompt. She reads responses, adds her own, and three people reply before her morning coffee is done. She already feels like she belongs somewhere.

Mid-week she has a question about her assignment. She posts it in the Module 2 thread. Two batchmates answer within three hours and her mentor adds a clarification. The entire exchange is searchable and tagged to Module 2 anyone with the same question six weeks later finds it instantly.

Thursday night she has two free hours but cannot bring herself to study alone. She opens the Study Rooms page. Eleven people are studying with cameras on some from her batch, some from the Data Science program. Nobody is talking. She turns her camera on and works for two full hours without touching her phone.

She asks the AI catch-up what she missed during the week. She gets a concise summary — a debate about product roadmaps, a resource on user research frameworks, an alumni

hosting a Q&A this Sunday. She joins it. The alumni is now a PM at a funded startup and opted in as a mentor on the platform. Weeks later, after consistently strong assignment performance, she unlocks alumni referral access, finds his profile, and sends a request. He reviews her projects and scores before accepting.

Twenty minutes of that conversation gives her more career clarity than everything she had read online.

Three months later she completed her course. She never once needed WhatsApp, Telegram, or LinkedIn. She tells her colleague to enroll. Her colleague asks about the student community. Priya says it is all inside the platform.

That is the outcome Accredian Connect is designed to create, every time.

6. Key Trade Offs & Decisions

Build internally vs integrate Slack or Discord Slack and Discord are strong general tools but have no awareness of courses, cohorts, or mentor roles. A student on Slack is just a workspace user. Integrating another third-party tool also defeats the purpose of keeping everything in one place.

Open Community vs fully course-specific communication Restricting everything to cohort groups creates a problem: cohorts are small and schedules vary. On slow days the community feels dead and students return to WhatsApp. The Open Community ensures there is always activity, always someone online, always a Study Room with people in it.

Study Rooms in Open Community vs Course Community Course-specific Study Rooms would be too dependent on cohort schedules to stay populated. Open Community Study Rooms work across all programs and time zones, which is what keeps them consistently active.

Limited profile visibility vs full public profiles Showing phone numbers, LinkedIn URLs, or academic scores publicly creates privacy concerns and shifts focus from learning to social networking. Deeper connections happen through the consent-based message request system.

Limited AI vs full AI assistant A general AI assistant replaces human conversation, which is the core value of this platform. AI is limited to two jobs catching up on missed discussions and tagging resources. Both add value without competing with the interactions the platform is built around.

Open alumni access vs selective opt-in Making all alumni available by default creates noise and overwhelms working professionals. Selective opt-in keeps the Alumni Mentor tag meaningful and every mentor on the platform genuinely willing to engage.

Open referral access vs performance-based access Allowing every student to request referrals from day one floods alumni mentors with requests from people they know nothing about. Tying referral access to academic performance assignment scores, project quality,

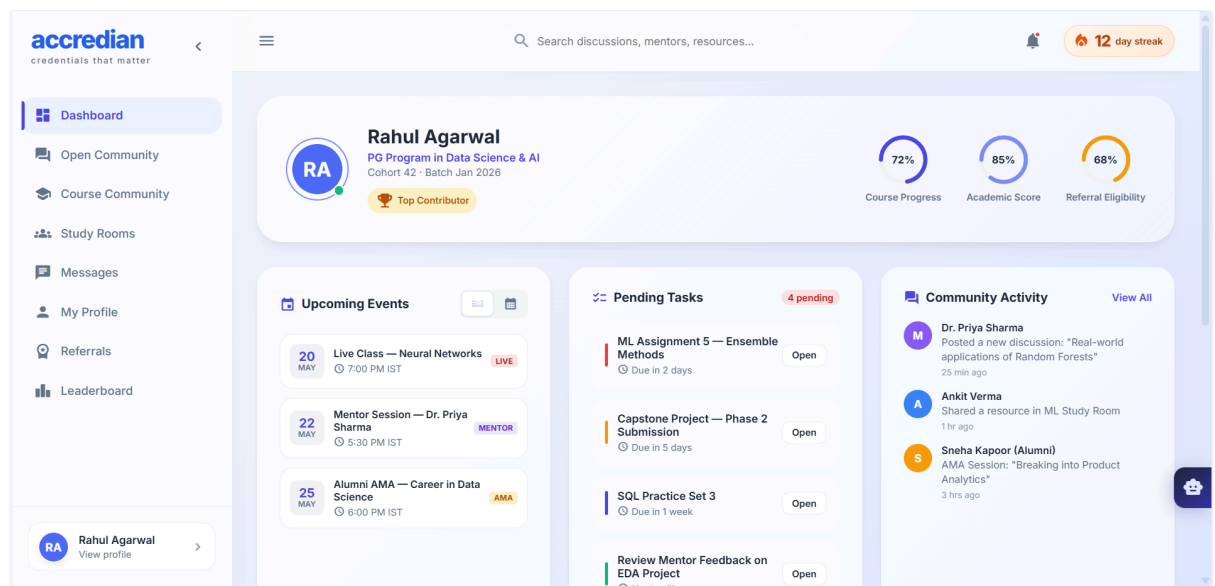
course progress protects mentor time and ensures every referral interaction is between a serious student and a willing mentor.

7. Concept Mocks

Live Prototype: <https://accerdian-connect-pm.vercel.app/>

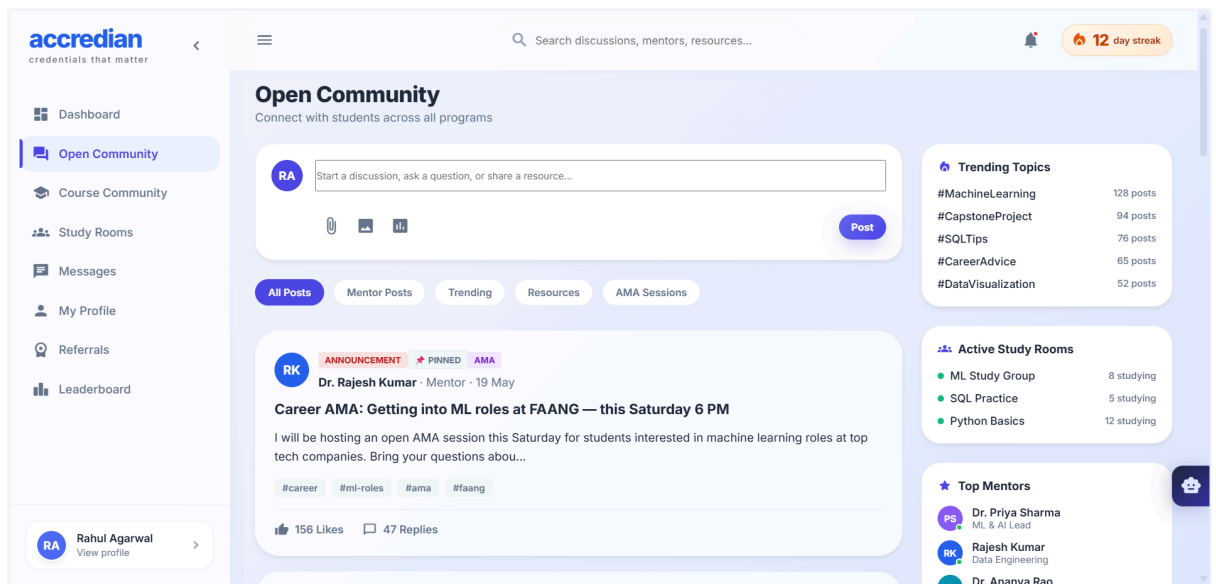
All screens below are from a working prototype built to demonstrate the full Accredian Connect experience.

Screen 1 : Main Dashboard



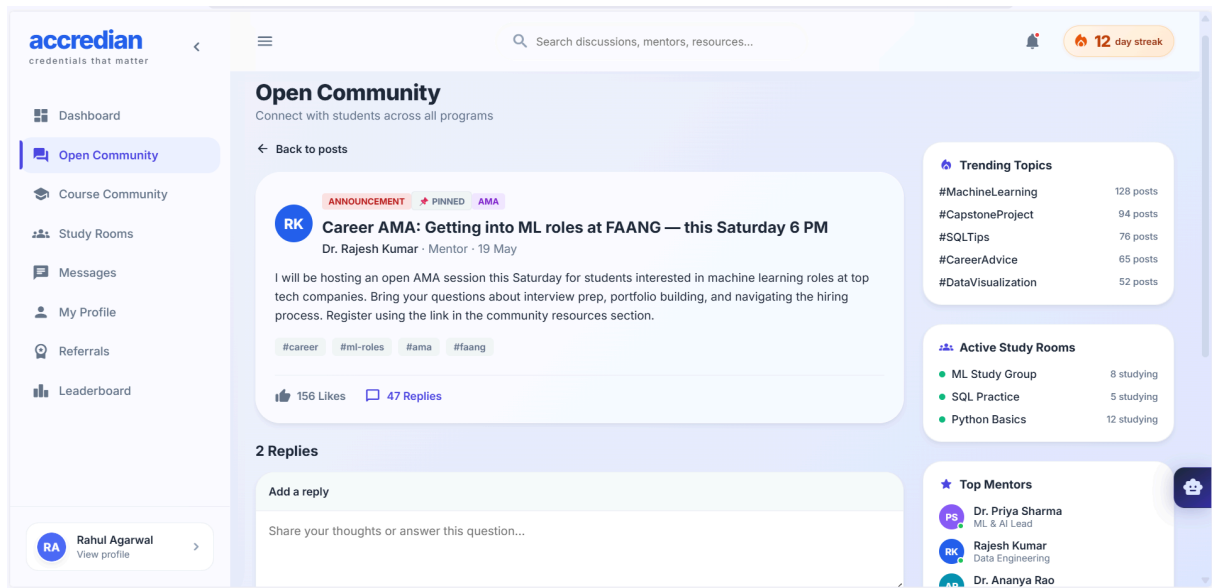
The entry point after login. Shows the student's profile card with active badges and study streak, three progress rings for Course Progress, Academic Score, and Referral Eligibility, upcoming events (live classes, mentor sessions, alumni AMAs), pending assignments with deadlines, and a live community activity feed. Everything a student needs to know about their week is visible without navigating anywhere else.

Screen 2 : Open Community Feed



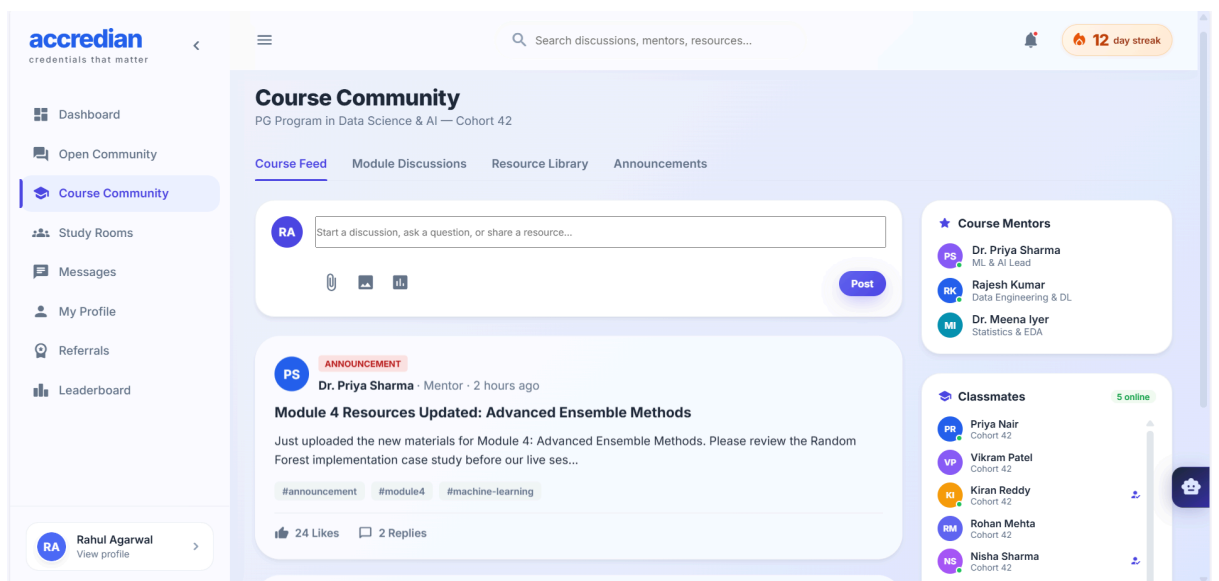
Cross-program public discussion feed with filter tabs All Posts, Mentor Posts, Trending, Resources, AMA Sessions. The right sidebar shows Trending Topics with post counts, Active Study Rooms with live participant numbers, and Top Mentors. Pinned mentor announcements stay visible regardless of feed activity below.

Screen 3 : Open Community Post Detail



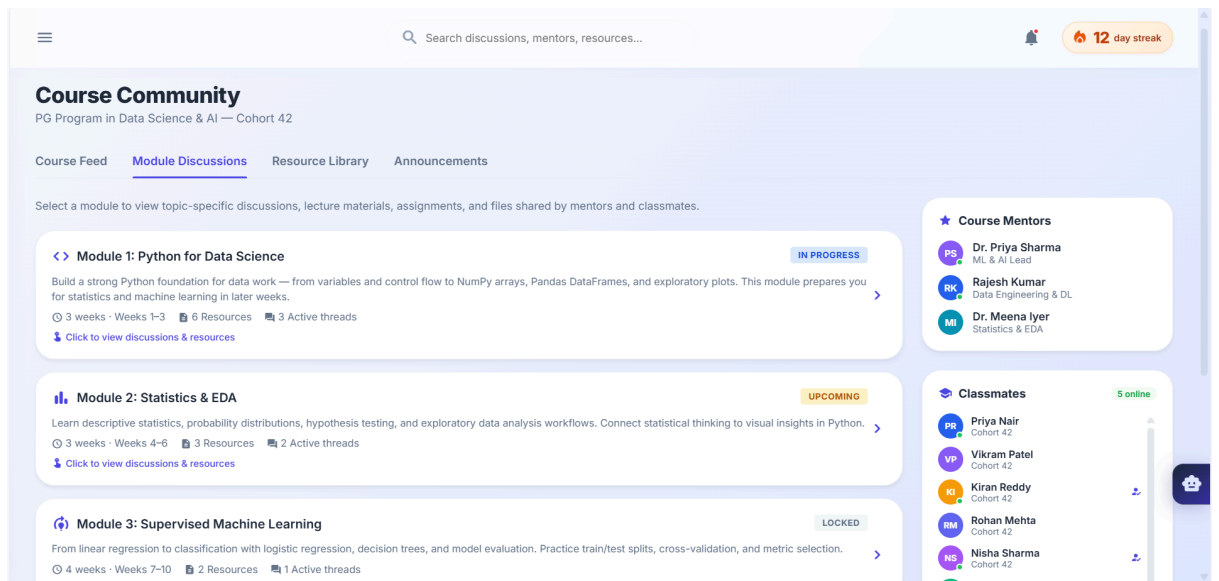
Full post view with complete content, reply thread, and reply composer. The right sidebar remains visible so students stay aware of the broader community even while reading a single thread.

Screen 4 : Course Community Feed



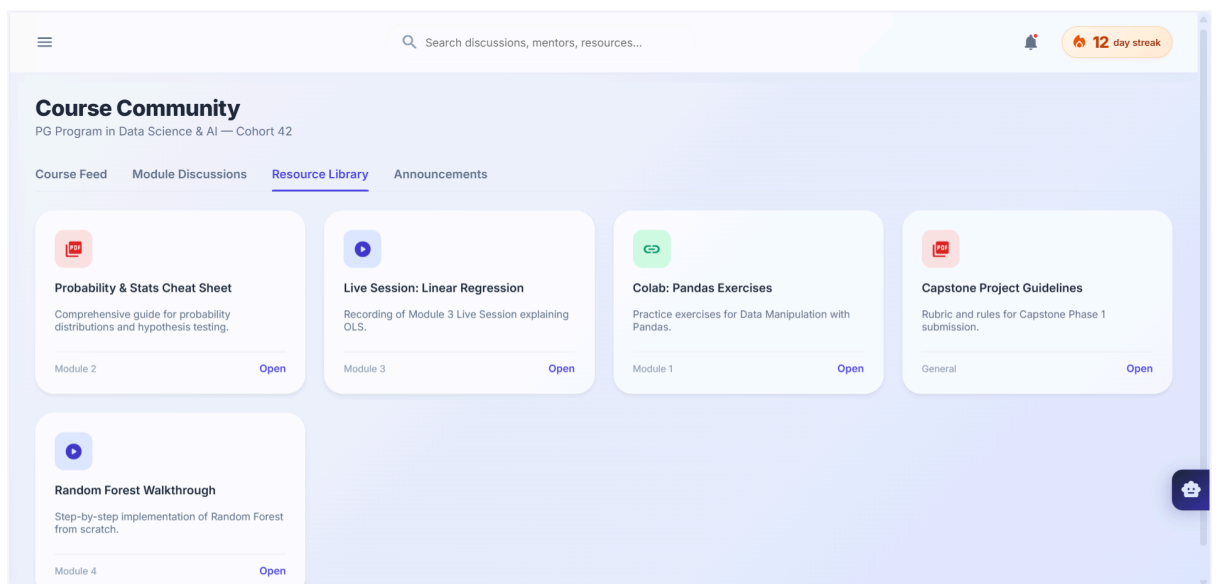
Private cohort space. Header confirms program name and cohort number. Four tabs Course Feed, Module Discussions, Resource Library, Announcements organize all content by purpose. Mentor posts are tagged clearly to distinguish them from peer discussions.

Screen 5 : Module Discussions



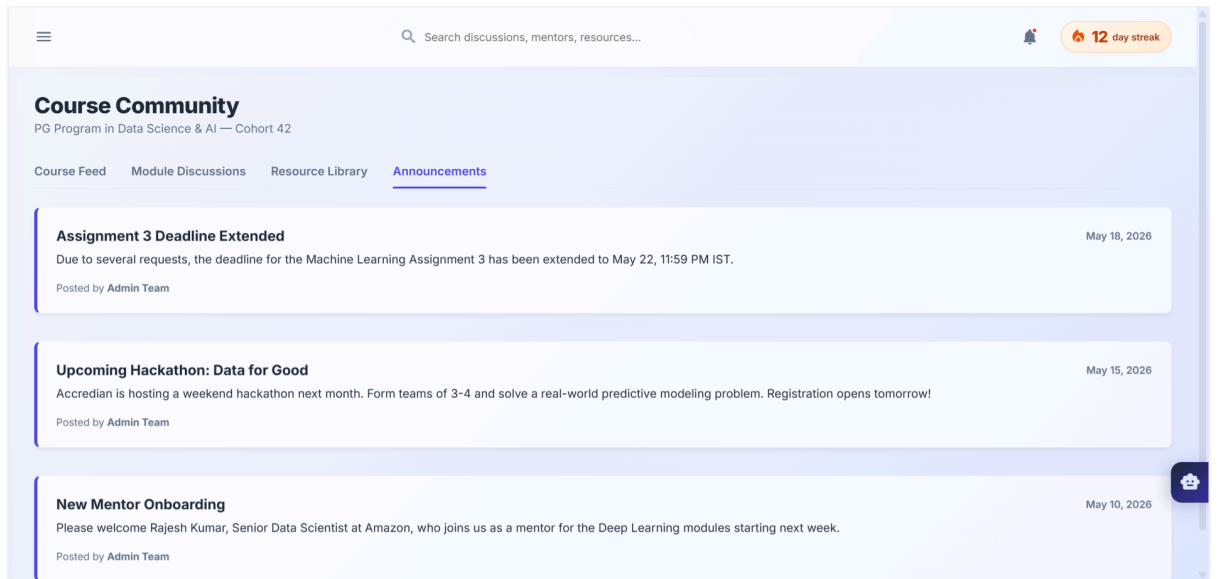
Each module has its own card showing resource count and discussion count. Students go directly to the module they are working on instead of searching through a general feed. This is the clearest demonstration of what makes Accredian Connect irreplaceable compared to WhatsApp — everything is organized, searchable, and tied to the actual course structure.

Screen 6 : Resource Library



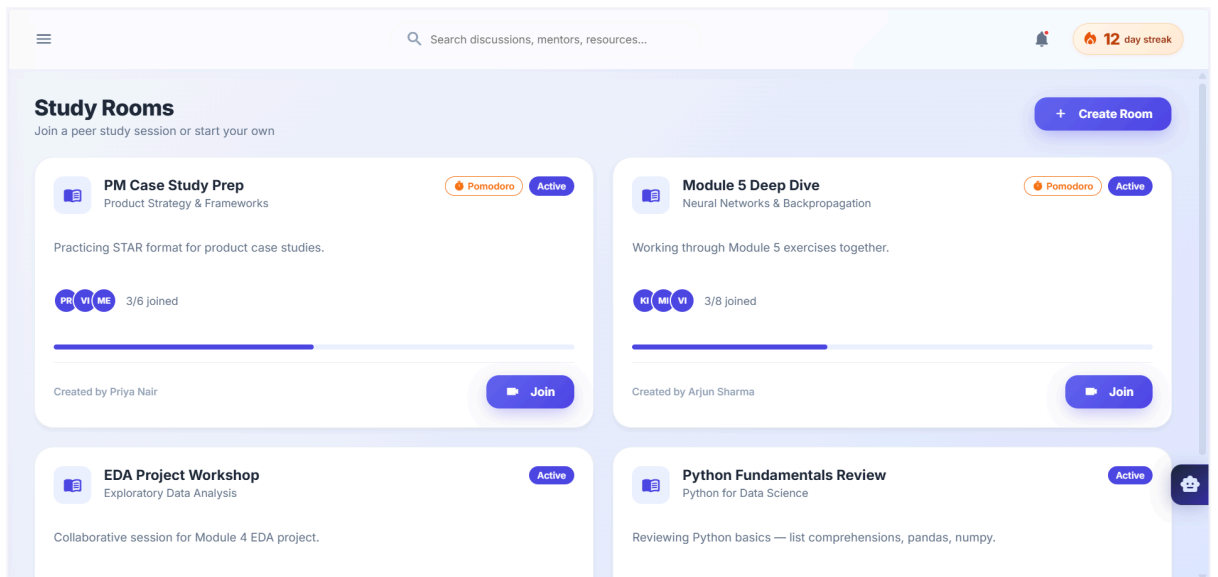
Resources displayed as cards with file type icons, title, description, module tag, and an open button. Every resource is automatically tagged by module through AI. PDFs, session recordings, and practice notebooks are all in one organized place.

Screen 7 : Announcements



Dedicated tab for official announcements from admin and mentors. Displayed as dated cards with a left border accent. Deadline extensions, hackathon registrations, new mentor introductions — all separated from general discussion so nothing critical gets missed.

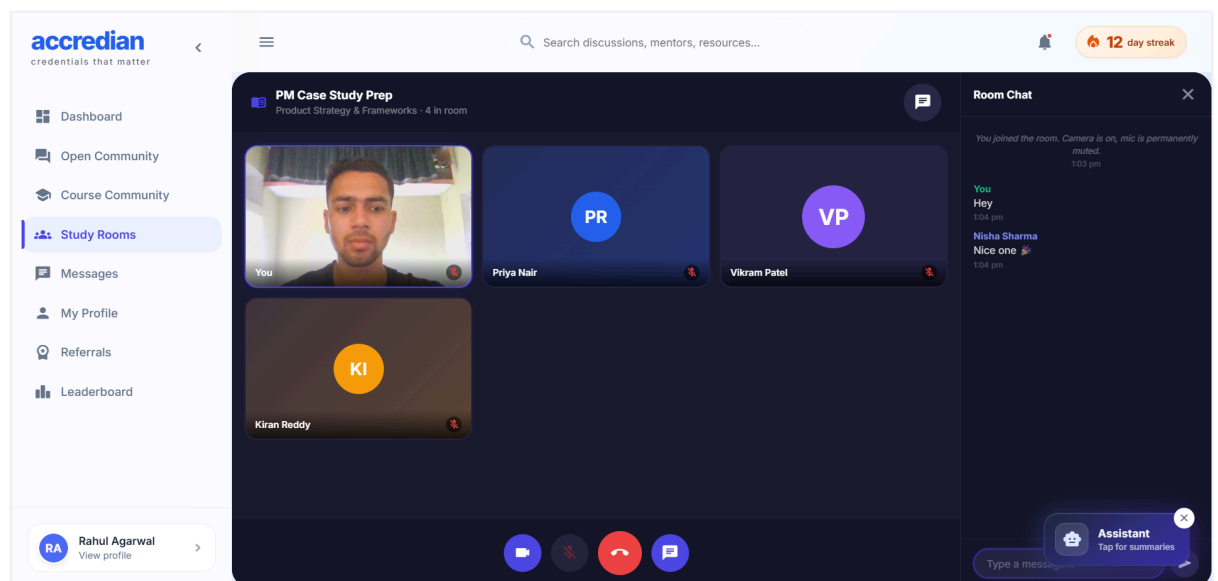
Screen 8 : Study Rooms Listing



Each room card shows name, topic, description, participant avatars, slots filled out of capacity, Pomodoro timer indicator, active status, creator name, and a join button. The

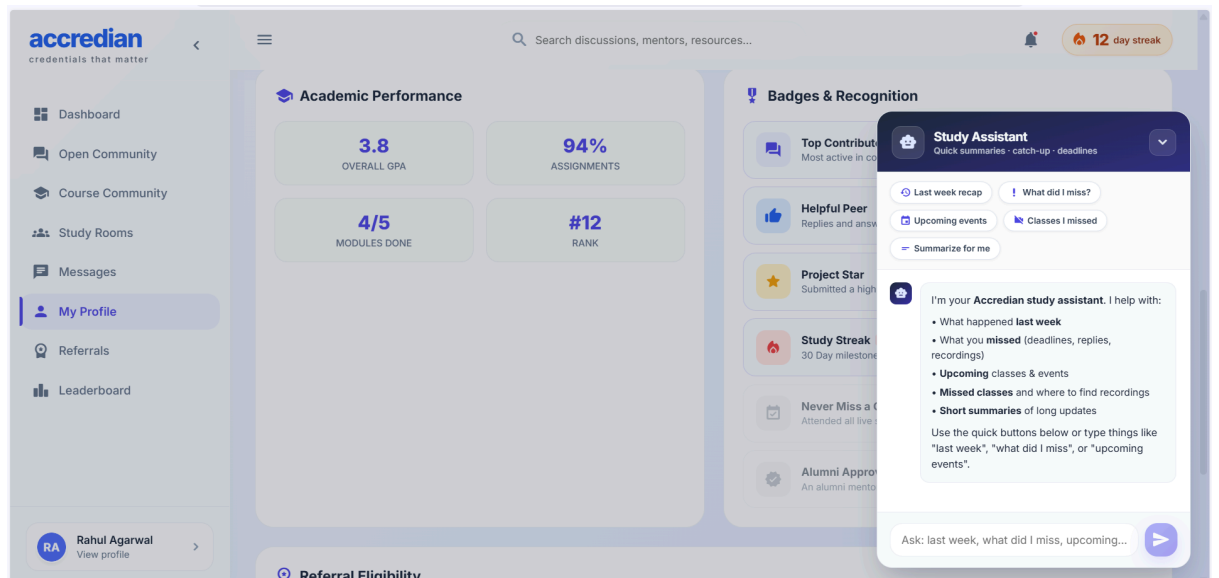
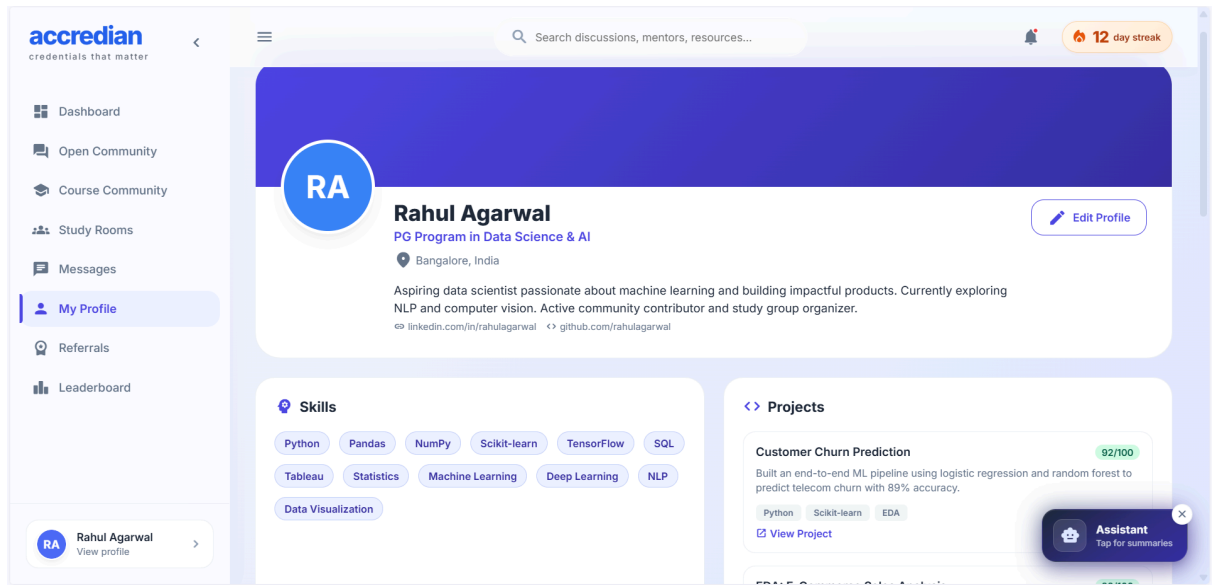
capacity progress bar creates social urgency. Rooms span multiple programs so there is always an active session available.

Screen 9 : Study Room Live View



Dark mode environment inside the room. Participants with cameras on appear as video tiles. Those without appear as avatar initials. The mic muted icon is visible on every tile. A system message confirms on entry — camera is on, mic is permanently muted. The Room Chat panel on the right allows text communication for the full room. Bottom controls show camera toggle, locked mic button, leave button, and chat toggle.

Screen 10 : My Profile



Student profile visible to mentors and alumni when reviewing connection requests. Shows name, program, batch, location, and bio. Five sections below: Skills, Projects, Academic Performance, Badges and Recognition, and Referral Eligibility. No phone numbers or personal contact details are ever shown.

8. Badges & Recognition

Badges appear on the student profile and are visible to mentors and alumni when reviewing connection requests. They signal both academic seriousness and community contribution.

Badge

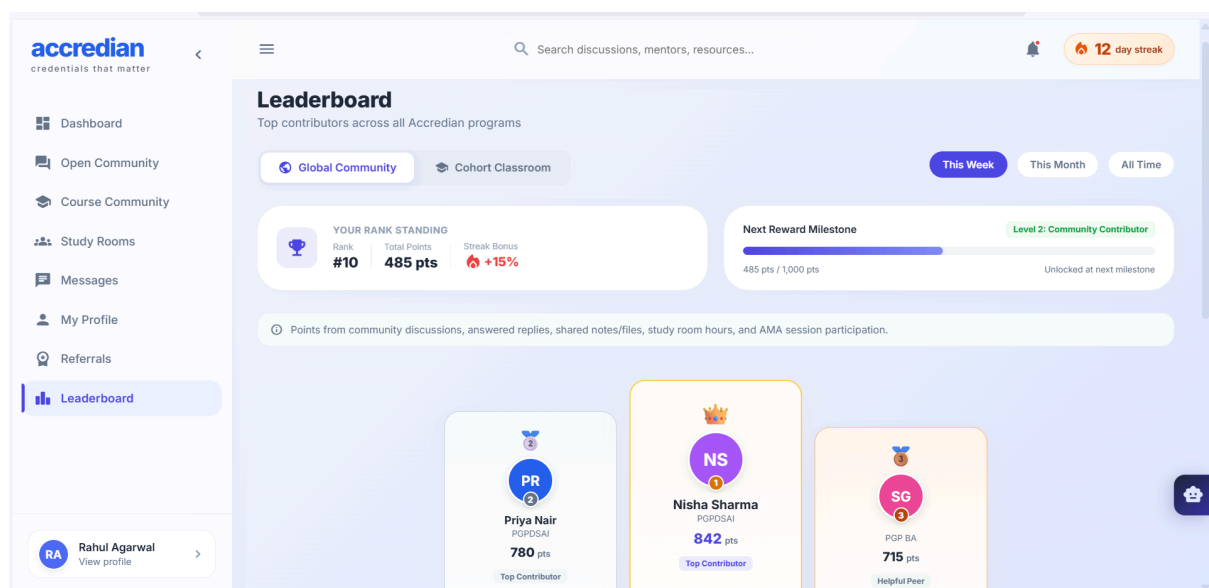
How It Is Earned

Top Contributor Most active discussion participant in cohort or open community

Helpful Peer	Replies and answers that received the most likes from other students
Project Star	High quality capstone or module project rated by a mentor
Study Streak	Consistent daily or weekly platform activity 7 Day, 30 Day, and 100 Day milestones
Never Miss a Class	Attended every live session in a given month
Alumni Approved	An alumni mentor personally endorsed the student after a referral interaction the hardest badge to earn

The profile shows the three most recently earned or highest value badges prominently. Remaining badges are accessible through a view of all options. Alumni Approved carries the most weight it requires academic eligibility, a meaningful interaction, and a deliberate choice by the alumni to endorse. When a mentor sees this on a student profile, they already know this person is worth their time.

9. Leaderboard



The Leaderboard is split into two separate rankings. Mixing community participation with academic performance in one list would create an unfair and misleading comparison.

Community Leaderboard : visible across all programs

Ranks students based on contribution to the broader Accredian Connect community. Points come from starting discussions that generate engagement, posting replies that receive likes, sharing resources, Study Room hours logged, and AMA sessions attended.

Cohort Leaderboard : visible only within the same batch

Ranks students based on academic engagement and course performance. Points come from assignment scores, project quality ratings from mentors, module discussion participation, live class attendance, and overall course progress.

Each leaderboard card shows rank number, student name and batch, avatar, total points for the period, top badges earned, and a directional arrow showing rank change from the previous week.

Time filters available: This Week, This Month, All Time. Weekly resets keep the competition fair and give every student a fresh start each week.

One additional recognition for the Cohort Leaderboard: the top three students each week are flagged to their mentor, who can choose to give them a public shoutout in the Course Community. For working professionals who rarely get recognized for their learning effort, this small acknowledgment carries real motivational weight.

10. Product Metrics

Engagement

- Daily and weekly active users inside Open and Course Communities
- Average discussion participation rate per student per week
- Study Room sessions joined and average session duration
- Resources shared and searched per week

Retention

- Weekly returning user rate
- Study Streak continuation rate across the student base
- Community participation rate outside of live class hours
- Reduction in external communication groups created by enrolled students

Career Outcomes

- Number of students reaching referral eligibility within their course duration
- Alumni mentor response rate to connection requests
- Referral interactions initiated and completed through the platform
- Post-course platform activity rate among graduates

11. How We Launch

Phase 1: The Pilot Launch. Begin with a single cohort where mentors are onboarded in advance. By pre-populating discussion prompts and resources, we ensure the platform provides immediate value from day one, preventing the "empty room" effect that drives students elsewhere.

Ongoing : Continuous Validation. Actively monitor for the creation of external WhatsApp groups. The existence of such groups serves as a primary signal that specific community needs are unmet, requiring rapid iteration before further scaling.

Phase 2: Community Expansion. Once the pilot proves stable, the Open Community is activated for all programs. This stage introduces cross-program Study Rooms to ensure consistent activity and motivation regardless of individual cohort schedules.

Phase 3: High-Engagement Layer. In the final stage, enable the Badges, Leaderboard, and Referral Eligibility systems. These merit-based mechanisms are deployed only when a critical mass of active users is reached to ensure these recognitions carry genuine weight.

Rollout Target. Full platform-wide rollout targeted within 90 days of launch.

12. Risks & Mitigations

Students do not switch from WhatsApp Habit and familiarity makes switching feel like unnecessary effort for a busy professional.

Mitigation: The Course Community is set up and active before a student even attends their first class. Their mentor has already posted. There is already activity. The platform never feels empty on day one, the most critical moment for habit formation. Study Rooms, AI catch-up, and referral access are things WhatsApp cannot offer, giving students a tangible reason to engage here instead.

Community activity drops over time Most online communities start with energy and slowly go quiet.

Mitigation: Mentor participation is a defined expectation, not optional. One discussion prompt per week minimum, with responses to unanswered student questions within 48 hours. Study Streaks, weekly Leaderboard resets, and scheduled alumni AMA sessions create recurring reasons to return beyond the initial excitement.

Mentors do not participate consistently If mentors treat the platform as optional, the Course Community becomes inactive and students return to WhatsApp.

Mitigation: Engagement expectations are set upfront as part of the mentor role. The commitment is low one weekly prompt, timely responses, occasional recognition of strong contributions. The visible impact on how alive the community feels is disproportionately high.

Alumni mentors get overwhelmed with requests Even with opt-in access, unfiltered requests will cause alumni to disengage.

Mitigation: Performance-based eligibility filters requests at the source. Only students who have met academic benchmarks can initiate referral connections. Alumni also set their own availability status so students know when outreach is welcome.

Privacy concerns reduce participation Students may hesitate to post publicly inside an academic platform.

Mitigation: Only name and batch are publicly visible. No personal contact details. Private messaging requires explicit consent. Accredian communicates clearly from day one that this is a learning community, not a monitoring tool.

Low quality content in Open Community Opening a space to all students across all programs always carries the risk of off-topic or low-effort content taking over.

Mitigation: Community guidelines are visible from the moment a student joins. A one-tap reporting system lets students flag content for moderator review. The message request system limits bad actors since they cannot reach anyone directly without consent.

Study Rooms go unused. Silent camera study rooms are an unfamiliar concept for many students.

Mitigation: Camera is completely optional students benefit from joining even without video. Participant counts on each room card create social pull. Culture builds gradually once early adopters talk about it in the community and others follow.

13. Appendix

Why Students Default to External Platforms

The problem is not that WhatsApp is a better product for learning. The problem is that Accredian has no peer communication space at all. When there is a gap, students fill it with whatever they already know. WhatsApp wins by default, not by merit.

Accredian Connect does not need to win a messaging competition. It needs to offer what WhatsApp cannot: academic context, organized information, career access, and a reason to stay engaged long after class ends. That is a winnable position.

Observations From Accredian's Own Platform

Each program has its own cohort with specific start dates and admission deadlines. However these details are not consistently visible across course pages; some show cohort information clearly, others show nothing. Accredian Connect surfaces upcoming cohort dates for all

programs inside the Open Community, giving students and prospective applicants easy access without hunting through individual course pages.

The Accredian blog has no comment section. The last post was from early 2025 with nothing published in 2026. Testimonials follow the same pattern. Engagement with the platform drops sharply after course completion and there is currently no mechanism to prevent it. The Open Community directly addresses this by creating an ongoing, searchable discussion space that keeps alumni connected to the platform long after graduation.

Competitive Analysis

WhatsApp: Fast and familiar but resources disappear within hours, there is no structure by topic or module, and there is no distinction between casual messages and critical updates. Students use it because nothing better exists inside the platform.

LinkedIn: Used for alumni discovery but it is a professional showcase, not a communication tool. Cold outreach feels formal, response rates are low, and identifying who completed a specific Accredian program is nearly impossible.

Telegram: Used as a file sharing channel. No organization, no module context, and files are effectively unfindable after 48 hours.

Discord: The closest existing product to Accredian Connect. Strong community culture, organized channels, and voice rooms. The Study Rooms concept is directly inspired by how students globally use Discord study servers. However Discord has no connection to courses, assignments, or cohorts; it is a general platform that students repurpose for studying. Accredian Connect takes Discord's strongest idea and places it inside an academic context where it becomes significantly more useful.

Each external platform solves one part of the problem. Accredian Connect brings all of it together and adds what none of them offer: academic context, structured mentorship, organized resources, and a merit-based career access system. A student never needs to leave Accredian for any part of their learning journey.

Target User

A working professional between 25 and 35 years old, enrolled in a 6 to 12 month Accredian program. Studying on weekends. Balancing work, learning, and personal responsibilities. Not looking for more apps, looking for fewer apps that do more, organized in a way that respects limited time and effort.

Accredian Connect is built for exactly this person.

All screens shown in Section 7 are from a working prototype built for this submission. Live prototype available at the link provided at the top of this document.